UNIT 3: EXPLORING CAREERS

TOPIC 1: INDIVIDUAL AND TRANSFERABLE SKILLS

Topic OBJECTIVES: The learner will:

- Understand the meanings of personal and transferable skills
- Identify their personal and transferable skills
- Increase his or her understanding of the range of skills sought by employers
- Explore how they can apply their understanding of their skills and interests to finding a job
- Explore careers of interest

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Obtain or strengthen knowledge and skills that will help them to search for a job
- Develop a list of their personal skills that will assist them with matching their transferable skills with position requirements
- Complete a career assessment and explore related jobs

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Large Group Discussion

Objectives:
- Students will understand the meanings of personal, job, and transferable skills.
- Students will explore how knowing and growing their own skill set can be a tool to finding a satisfying career.

Time: 15 minutes

Materials: Handout: **"Individual Skills,"** pens/pencils, chart paper/markers

Ask students to name a skill they have, or a skill they think is needed for a job they might like. Explain that there are three basic types of skills — individual, job, and transferable. Explain that "individual skills" such as being prompt, organized, loyal, or flexible are valued on the job site. "Job skills" are usually learned on the job, and "transferable skills" are learned in one setting, but can "carry over" to another occupation.

On chart paper, make a column for each of the three skill types, and have students name some skills, and where they might belong.

Hand out **"Individual Skills,"** and have students circle at least three skills they possess. Some students may need definitions of the skills, so be prepared to help define and/or have dictionaries or a web dictionary available if possible.

Writing/Reflection/Assessment

Objectives:
- Students will be able to identify many of the skills employers are looking for when hiring new staff.
- Students will identify their own set of "transferable and personal skills."

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handout: **"Skills Today's Employers Expect,"** pens/pencils

Hand out **"Skills Today's Employer's Expect,"** and explain that students will rate themselves on each of these skills. Afterwards, discuss the listed skills. Were people surprised at what skills are expected? What areas do they feel most or least confident in? Where can people go to improve their skills and/or learn new ones?

Technical (Mass CIS)/Research

Objectives:
- Students will participate in a detailed, online career assessment, that will help them focus on their strongest skill areas and identify related careers.
- Students will add a completed "Skills" assessment to their paper, electronic, and online portfolios.

Time: 25 minutes

Materials: Computers with internet connection, note cards with names and passwords, pens/pencils, printer (to print out individual results for Student Career Portfolio)

Have students log onto **Mass CIS** and click on the **"SKILLS"** link under the Assessment Tools heading in the lower left corner. After students have completed the assessment and explored related jobs, have them save their results to their **Mass CIS** portfolio and their flash drive, and print for paper portfolio.

Individual Skills

Circle the individual qualities and skills that you have. Be prepared to tell things you do that show you have this quality. Use the dictionary if you're not sure of a word's meaning.

academic
active
accurate
affectionate
aggressive
ambitious
analytical
artistic
assertive
athletic

businesslike

dependable
determined

easygoing
energetic
enthusiastic
expressive

fair-minded
flexible
formal
friendly

generous
genuine
giving

hardworking
healthy
honest
humorous
independent
industrious
informal
intelligent

kind
logical

loyal

mature

neat

open-minded
optimistic
organized

patient
perceptive
polite
practical
productive
progressive
punctual

quick learner

realistic
reasonable
responsible

self-confident
sensible
strong
supportive
sympathetic

tactful
task-oriented
teachable
thorough
thoughtful
trustworthy

understanding

well-groomed
witty

Skills Today's Employers Expect

This list of skills was compiled by the Colorado Department of Education. Four hundred companies were surveyed as to the specific skills they wanted their employees to have.

How many do you have? How can you best learn and practice these skills? Put an **X** if you have the skill, put an **L** if you're learning the skill, put a **W** if you're weak in that skill.

Reading Skills

- _____ Read for details and specific information
- _____ Interpret pictorial information such as graphs, charts, diagrams, and maps
- _____ Use source materials and do research
- _____ Follow intent of written instructions
- _____ Interpret ideas and concept
- _____ Read accurately within a given time

Mathematical Skills

- _____ Handle basic calculations — add, subtract, multiply, divide
- _____ Estimate quantities needed on the job
- _____ Calculate costs
- _____ Use values from charts, diagrams, manuals, and tables
- _____ Construct diagrams, charts, records
- _____ Research and use statistics
- _____ Use formulas — at least Algebra I
- _____ Use 10 key calculator to complete above tasks

Computer Skills

- _____ Become aware of computer functions
- _____ Input data into computers
- _____ Access data from computers
- _____ Perform simple programming
- _____ Perform word processing

Manual/Perceptual Skills

- _____ Construct, assemble materials
- _____ Use job-specific hand tools
- _____ Develop visual presentations
- _____ Use keyboard skills
- _____ Operate job-specific power equipment

Writing Skills

- _____ Write legibly
- _____ Complete forms accurately
- _____ Write sentences in STANDARD ENGLISH
- _____ Organize, select, relate ideas
- _____ Produce reports and summaries
- _____ Identify and correct errors in writing-edit

Communication Skills

- _____ Give clear, oral instructions/directions
- _____ Explain activities and ideas clearly
- _____ Report accurately on what others have said
- _____ Stay on the topic in job-related conversations
- _____ Present information effectively
- _____ Speak clearly
- _____ Use appropriate vocabulary/grammar
- _____ Follow intent of oral instructions

Interpersonal Skills

_____ Function cooperatively with co-workers

_____ Function cooperatively with a team member

_____ Adhere to company policies and regulations

_____ Cooperate with clients/customers

_____ Exhibit openness and flexibility

_____ Seek clarification of instructions

_____ Exercise patience and tolerance

_____ Accept constructive supervision

_____ Exhibit leadership

_____ Understand supervisory authority and worker responsibility

Problem Solving/Critical Reasoning Skills

_____ Determine work activities — what needs to be done and when

_____ Use appropriate procedures

_____ Obtain resources

_____ Conduct work in appropriate sequence

_____ Recognize the effects of changing the quantity and quality of materials

_____ Collect and organize information

_____ Analyze and synthesize information

_____ Identify alternative approaches — different ways of doing the job

_____ Review progress periodically

_____ Evaluate for accuracy and completeness

_____ Correct deficiencies and problems

_____ Summarize and draw reasonable conclusions

_____ Deliver completed work on time

_____ Devise new ideas and better work methods

Job Retention and Career Development Skills

_____ Participate in training

_____ Pursue education outside the job

_____ Become aware of company operations

_____ Learn about employee benefits and responsibilities

_____ Suggest and/or make workplace improvements

_____ Accept additional responsibilities

_____ Maintain consistent effort

_____ Make efficient use of new technology

_____ Work with a positive attitude towards job and co-workers

_____ Adapt to different job assignments

_____ Maintain acceptable appearance

_____ Keep work area clean and organized

_____ Exhibit interest in future career development

_____ Indicate interest in future career development

_____ Be punctual

_____ Avoid missing work

Think about it:

Circle five of your strong skills.

Circle five skills you'll improve through practice.

Look at the ten skills you circled. Even strong skills can be improved.

Where and how can you strengthen all ten of these skills?

Adapted from Merging Two Worlds, 2003